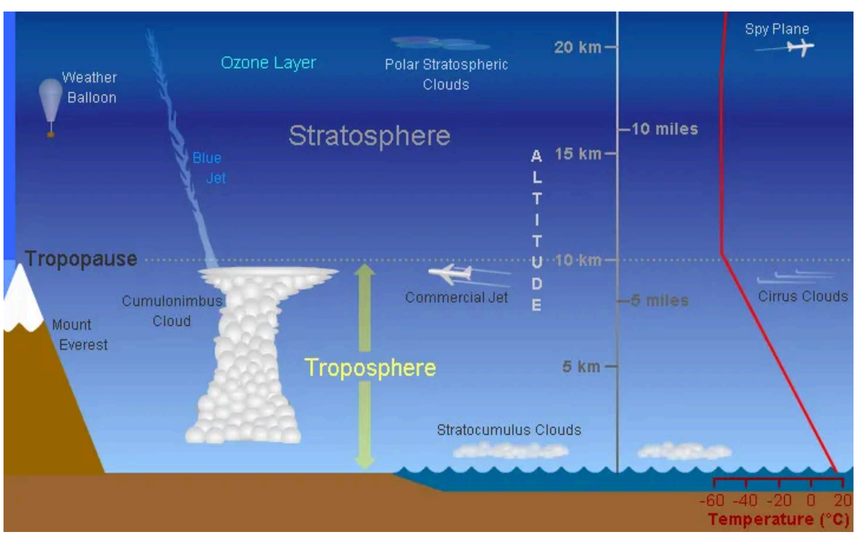
The Troposphere

The troposphere is the lowest layer of Earth's atmosphere. Most of the mass (about 75-80%) of the atmosphere is in the troposphere. Most types of clouds are found in the troposphere, and almost all weather occurs within this layer. The troposphere is by far the wettest layer of the atmosphere (all of the other layers contain very little moisture).



This diagram shows some of the features of the

7 km (4 miles or 23,000 feet) over the poles in winter.

Air is warmest at the bottom of the troposphere near ground level. Air gets colder as one rises through the troposphere. That's why the peaks of tall mountains can be snow-covered even in the summertime.

Air pressure and the density of the air also decrease as altitude increases. Jet aircraft often fly just above the tropopause, which is the boundary between the troposphere and the more stable stratosphere. Because of the decrease in air pressure with height, the cabins of these high-flying jet aircraft are pressurized.

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